



rifle proceeded at a much slower pace. In 1956, firearms designers Eugene Stoner and L. James Sullivan developed a small-caliber rifle for the Armalite company of the Netherlands. This became the M16—the US Army’s standard assault rifle. The US Army used it in the 1960s against North Vietnamese Communist forces armed with the AK47 in the Vietnam War.

The M16 was lighter, more accurate, and fired more quickly than the AK47, but was prone to jamming in adverse conditions. However, it provided the US troops with a fitting response to the unstoppable AK47 in a bloody jungle war.

THE AK47 AND ITS AFTERMATH

The AK47 was reliable in war conditions—it continued to fire despite exposure to sand, water, and weather. Easy to maintain and simple in design, its workings could be grasped in minutes and, even in untrained hands, it became a formidable weapon that changed the rules of modern warfare. It demystified the gun and its usage for ordinary people, and gave untrained warriors the ability to wield immense firepower. It brought about a new

trend in warfare in which irregular combatants (guerillas) and terrorists could hold out against well-trained armies.

The assault rifle has emerged as the main weapon in modern warfare—from civil wars in Africa, to conflicts in the Middle East, to local turf wars—in the hands of militaries, terrorists, militias, and even child soldiers.

Modern assault rifles can provide accurate fire in volume at distances well in excess of 1,600ft (500m). Short-cased, small-caliber cartridges continue to be used. The assault rifle’s deadly combination of a light machine-gun’s firepower and a machine-pistol’s portability makes it a popular weapon with untrained combatants.

- **NEW PRODUCTION METHODS** developed. With the incorporation of synthetic materials into its construction, the modern assault rifle is far less likely to suffer a catastrophic failure of its components due to stress and wear.
- **FIRE CONTROL MECHANISMS** improved. This allowed modern assault rifles to fire a specific number of cartridges in a single burst, increasing accuracy and making the weapons deadlier than ever.

▲ THE VIETNAM WAR

The M16 was deployed for warfare in South Vietnam in 1965. Its ability to focus a large volume of fire on a target made it quite effective, especially at close quarters against enemy guerilla tactics. Seen here are US soldiers armed with M16s in a Vietnamese jungle.

AFTER »

- **THE “BULLPUP” CONFIGURATION** (see pp.250–51), as seen in the Famas F1 assault rifle, served two purposes. It lessened a weapon’s overall length and placed the user totally in line with the barrel, thus reducing the effects of recoil.



**FAMAS F1
ASSAULT RIFLE**

- **HIGH CASUALTIES** have become the norm of modern warfare with the use of the assault rifle. Its move from the battleground to the streets has triggered a debate about its usage by nonmilitary personnel.